Revision Date:
February 1, 2022

Background:
CalWORKs recipients who are referred to Employment Services (ES) are required to attend an Orientation (ORE) and complete an Appraisal (APR) to identify abilities, skills, education, and work history, as well as potential barriers to self-sufficiency. The Online CalWORKs Appraisal Tool (OCAT) will be used to document the Appraisal interview and outcome.

Purpose:
The purpose of this revision is to streamline policies and remove Orientation and Appraisal procedures from the program guide. A corresponding Processing Guide (10-005.D1) has been created for this purpose.

Policy:
ES ORE is to be conducted prior to APR. The ORE and APR must be completed within 15 business days of the ES referral date for individuals who are:

- New ES participants
- Referred to ES as Exempt Volunteers
- Re-referred to ES after a break in aid of 30 calendar days or more, after an exemption lasting 30 days or more, or as mandatory participants after an Exempt Voluntary status has ended
- Sanctioned participants referred to ORE/APR to cure the sanction

OCAT
The OCAT is an online appraisal tool that is used to assist the Employment Case Manager (ECM) to identify abilities, skills, education and work history, as well as identify potential barriers to self-sufficiency. The OCAT will be used to document APR interview discussions, unless the participant declines to complete the OCAT, or the OCAT cannot be administered entirely due to language translation not being appropriate for sensitive sections addressing mental health/substance use or domestic abuse. In those instances, participants must be referred directly to the appropriate evaluations rather than using the OCAT for screening.

A participant will not be sanctioned for declining to complete the OCAT. However, a sanction may apply if the participant refuses or fails to complete APR via Form 27-01 without good cause. A participant will be considered compliant with the appraisal process even if they do not wish to disclose answers to specific questions in OCAT, as long as they complete the required APR forms and provide enough information to the ECM to evaluate for the appropriate ES activity.

Behavioral Health Screenings
Behavioral Health for Substance Use and Mental Health screenings are required at the time of APR for all recipients referred to ES. After ORE is completed, the regional Behavioral Health Services contractor will screen the participant in a private setting.

Learning Disabilities Screening
ECMs must offer participants a screening for Learning Disabilities (LD) at ORE/APR. Information must be provided both verbally and in writing about the screening.

Domestic Violence
If a customer discloses being a victim of domestic violence during APR, the ECM is not required to ask questions related to the alleged perpetrator in the domestic abuse section to avoid placing the victim at further risk of abuse if the participant's partner is present.

OCAT Action Plan and Referral/Evaluation Status
An action plan contains specific actions that the ECM assigns to a participant in order to comply with the recommendations in OCAT. An action plan and referral/evaluation status must be completed by the ECM for each recommendation generated by OCAT for each participant. The recommendations may include evaluation for Family Stabilization (FS), Self-Initiated Programs (SIPs), ES exemptions, Job Search (JS), and/or an assessment for education/training. These recommendations are to be used to determine the next best steps for the participant in the ES process and assign the most appropriate activities.

Appraisal Summary and Recommendations (ASR)
The ASR is a printout from OCAT with the participant's demographic, household and financial information, strengths, barriers, recommendations, and action items. The ASR does not require a signature.

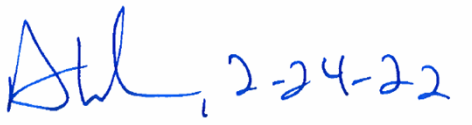
Procedure:
Processing Guide 10-005.D1

Impacts:
None

References:
EAS 42-711.52, ACL 15-43, ACL 15-69, ACL 16-67, ACL 21-04

Sunset Date:
This policy will be reviewed for continuance by February 28, 2025.

Approval for Release:



Rick Wanne, Director
Self-Sufficiency Services